Reference

Glossary

Short, family-friendly explanations for the abbreviations and terms used in this site's tournament tables - written so a first-time reader never has to guess what a shorthand means. See `docs/EDITORIAL_GUIDE.md`'s terminology rules for the list this page exists to satisfy.

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a.e.t.

Short for **after extra time**. When a knockout match is still level after 90 minutes, two more 15-minute halves are played before anything else is decided. "a.e.t." next to a final score means that score is what stood after those extra 30 minutes, before any penalty shoot-out.

pens

Short for **a penalty shoot-out**. When a knockout match is still level after full time - and extra time, where it was played - each side takes penalty kicks in turn until a winner is settled. "pens" next to a final score marks the shoot-out result that decided the match.

runner-up

The team or player that finished second. This site always says "runner-up", never "second winner" - there is only one winner.

semifinalist

For UEFA EURO from 1984 onward, both teams eliminated in the semifinals are called semifinalists rather than ranked third and fourth. Unlike the FIFA World Cup, EURO has not played a third-place match since 1980, so there is no match result to separate them.

third and fourth place

For the FIFA World Cup, UEFA Nations League, and Copa América, the two semifinal losers usually play a separate match to decide third and fourth place, so those two positions are normally ranked rather than tied. A handful of editions are exceptions - the FIFA World Cup's first tournament (1930) ranked third and fourth without playing that match, and several early or short-format Copa América editions settled (or, for three of them, never settled) those places a different way. See each competition's own historical notes for the specifics.

host

The country, or countries, that staged a tournament. For the FIFA World Cup, the host nation (or nations - the United States, Mexico, and Canada for 2026) is normally given a guaranteed place in the finals rather than having to qualify, and several UEFA EURO hosts have been granted the same guarantee - though not every UEFA EURO edition has worked that way, so check each competition's own notes rather than assuming one rule fits every tournament. The UEFA Nations League Finals is the clearest exception: UEFA only ever chooses its host from among the four teams that reach the Finals through the competition's own league phase and knockout rounds, so hosting that four-team event is never a substitute for qualifying. Copa América mostly sidesteps the question, since CONMEBOL's ten member nations - who host nearly every edition - take part regardless of who is hosting.

confederation

One of football's regional governing bodies - UEFA for Europe, CONMEBOL for South America, and others for the rest of the world - each of which runs its own continental competition and allocates FIFA World Cup qualifying places to its member countries.